RESEARCH REPORT

Institution's Innovation Council (IIC)

Structure, Scale, Scope, and Role in Indian Higher Education

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Executive Summary

The **Institution's Innovation Council (IIC)** is the world's largest network of innovation councils in higher education. Established in **November 2018** by India's Ministry of Education through its Innovation Cell (MIC) at AICTE headquarters in New Delhi, IIC is a government-mandated body inside every higher education institution, designed to systematically build a culture of innovation, entrepreneurship, and intellectual property awareness on campus.

Since inception, the network has grown from 950 institutions to over 16,400 functional councils, engaging more than 50 lakh (5 million) students and faculty across the country. IIC is not a student club or a voluntary initiative. It is a nationally standardised, measurably accountable framework with direct links to government programmes worth real funding, mentorship, and patent support.

This report provides a comprehensive overview of IIC for the students and faculty of IIT Bombay. It covers the programme's origin and policy context, governance structure, activity framework, national programmes, performance evaluation system, and its specific role within IIT Bombay's existing innovation ecosystem.

16,400+	50 Lakh+	1,02,000+	8
IICs Nationwide	Students & Faculty Engaged	Innovations Catalogued	Versions Since 2018

What is the Institution's Innovation Council?

The Institution's Innovation Council (IIC) is a faculty-led, student-centric council formed within a higher education institution under the direction of MIC (MoE's Innovation Cell). It operates on a hub-and-spoke model where MIC at AICTE headquarters is the hub, and each institution's IIC is a spoke.

Every IIC is formally registered on the national IIC portal (iic.mic.gov.in) and is assigned a unique registration ID. It conducts a structured calendar of innovation and entrepreneurship activities throughout the year, reports its performance quarterly to MIC, and is evaluated through a rigorous national star rating system.

Core Mission

The fundamental mission of IIC is to ensure that every higher education institution in India - regardless of size, location, resources, or prestige - has a functioning, accountable innovation ecosystem. This means creating awareness about innovation and entrepreneurship among students, helping them develop ideas into prototypes, facilitating access to intellectual property support, connecting them with mentors and funding, and ultimately contributing to India's position in the Global Innovation Index.

Official Objectives

- Create a vibrant local innovation ecosystem on campus through structured activities
- Encourage, inspire, and nurture young students by exposing them to new ideas and processes that drive innovation
- Provide mechanisms for institutionalising the innovation and startup culture at the institute level
- Establish a functional innovation ecosystem to promote industry-institute partnerships for innovation and entrepreneurship development
- Develop better cognitive abilities among students for novel approaches to problem-solving and design thinking
- Create awareness about intellectual property rights (IPR) and facilitate patent filing through the KAPILA programme
- Organise periodic workshops, hackathons, idea competitions, mentoring sessions, and networking events
- Support students to take their innovations from ideation to market through pre-incubation and incubation support

Origin and History

The Problem: Why IIC Was Needed

Before 2018, innovation and entrepreneurship activities at most Indian colleges were sporadic, unplanned, and disconnected from any national framework. While premier institutions like IITs and IIMs had established ecosystems - incubators, entrepreneurship cells, research parks - the vast majority of India's 40,000+ higher education institutions had no formal mechanism to foster innovation. Students with good ideas had nowhere to go; faculty lacked incentives to engage with innovation; and intellectual property awareness was virtually non-existent in most colleges.

The Solution: MIC and IIC

In **2018**, the Ministry of Human Resource Development (now Ministry of Education) established the **MoE's Innovation Cell (MIC)** at AICTE headquarters in New Delhi. **Dr. Abhay Jere** was appointed as India's first **Chief Innovation Officer (CIO)**. Under his leadership, MIC launched the IIC programme, formally inaugurated on **21 November 2018** at AICTE headquarters.

Policy Context

The IIC programme drew strength from a rich ecosystem of policy initiatives that were converging around innovation in Indian education:

Policy / Initiative	Year	Relevance to IIC
Atal Innovation Mission (AIM)	2016	Seeded Atal Tinkering Labs in schools; established innovation pipeline from school to college
Smart India Hackathon (SIH)	2017	Demonstrated massive student appetite for problem-solving; now coordinated via IIC
National Innovation & Startup Policy (NISP)	2019	Provided guidelines for IP ownership, technology licensing, and institutional startup policies
National Education Policy (NEP)	2020	Emphasised innovation, entrepreneurship, multidisciplinary education, and experiential learning
KAPILA Programme	2020	IP literacy and patent filing support; integrated into IIC activity calendar

Evolution: IIC 1.0 to IIC 8.0

The programme has evolved through eight major versions, each expanding scope and sharpening evaluation criteria:

Version	Period	Key Milestones
IIC 1.0	2018–19	Launch with 950+ councils; basic activity reporting framework established
IIC 2.0	2019–20	Semester-based calendars; choice-based scoring introduced
IIC 3.0	2020–21	Upgraded assessment framework; star rating system formalised
IIC 4.0	2021–22	Celebration Day activities added; four-category activity model
IIC 5.0	2022–23	Mentor-Mentee scheme; expanded activity types
IIC 6.0	2023–24	Refined star ratings; emphasis on innovation outputs
IIC 7.0	2024–25	Progressive quarterly themes; activity intensity levels introduced
IIC 8.0	2025–26	Announced; Indovation Centres; City Innovation Cluster expansion

Governance and Organisational Structure

National-Level Architecture

The IIC programme operates on a multi-tiered governance model. At the national level, MIC (housed within AICTE, New Delhi) serves as the central coordinating body. Dr. Abhay Jere, as Chief Innovation Officer, reports to the AICTE Chairman and works under the broader oversight of the Ministry of Education. The country is divided into eight zonal administrative regions for coordination and regional meets.

Institution-Level Council Composition

Each IIC follows a standardised governance template prescribed by MIC:

Role	Who Fills It	Key Responsibilities
President	Senior faculty member	Leads the IIC; holds portal login; calls meetings; monitors deliverables; primary contact with MIC
Vice President	Senior industry / ecosystem expert	Advisory role; brings external perspective and industry connections
Convenor	Faculty member	Operational logistics; prepares agendas; maintains documentation (minutes, photos, videos); coordinates members
Faculty Coordinators	Faculty members (5–7)	Dedicated roles for innovation activities, IPR, startups, NIRF, social media, and internships
Patent Expert	Registered patent agent (ideally)	Handles IP workshops and guides patent filing process
Innovation Ambassadors	Trained faculty	MIC-certified; must conduct minimum 4 activities per six months; serve as mentors
External Members	Alumni entrepreneurs, industry experts	Bring real-world experience; connect students to industry and investors
Student Coordinators	Selected students	Bridge between IIC and the broader student body; disseminate information; volunteer for events

Innovation Ambassador Programme

A cornerstone of IIC's knowledge infrastructure. Faculty are trained through MIC's structured programme covering four modules: Design Thinking, IPR and Technology Transfer, Pre-incubation Management, and Entrepreneurship Development. Over 25,000 faculty and school teachers have been certified as Innovation Ambassadors nationwide. Each ambassador must conduct at least four activities every six months to retain the designation.

The Four Pillars: IIC Activity Framework

Every IIC operates on a yearly calendar divided into four quarters (approximately July through June). Activities fall into four categories, each carrying specific weightage in the scoring system. The total minimum across all categories comes to roughly 36–40 activities per year. Top-performing IICs far exceed this, with some conducting over 80 activities annually.

Pillar 1: IIC Calendar Activities (40–50% of Score)

These are prescribed by MIC in the annual activity calendar. The minimum requirement is three per quarter (twelve per year). Typical activities include:

- Workshops on design thinking and creative problem-solving
- IPR awareness sessions under the KAPILA programme
- Entrepreneurship development programmes and startup boot camps
- Proof-of-concept and idea pitching sessions
- Field visits to incubators, maker spaces, and innovation hubs
- Inter-institutional innovation competitions

Pillar 2: MIC-Driven Activities (20% of Score)

Scheduled by MIC at its discretion, these are all mandatory. The number varies by year (typically 8–10 annually) and includes:

- India First Leadership Talk Series featuring national and international speakers
- Innovation Ambassador training sessions (multi-day programmes)
- IIC Regional Meets (held across eight zones)
- National campaigns like Viksit Bharat@2047 events and Innovation Day celebrations

Pillar 3: Self-Driven Activities (30% of Score)

Independently planned by IICs to suit their campus context. Minimum: three per quarter. These are where institutional creativity shines - hackathons tailored to local problems, industry mentoring sessions, startup demo days, alumni entrepreneur talks, innovation showcases, and field research expeditions.

Pillar 4: Celebration Day Activities (10% of Score)

Introduced in IIC 4.0, these involve observing nationally significant days. Minimum: one per quarter. Key dates include National Startup Day (January 16), World IP Day (April 26), National Science Day (February 28), National Youth Day (January 12), and others relevant to innovation.

IIC 8.0 Quarterly Themes

Q1: Awareness and Idea Generation | Q2: Skill Development | Q3: Prototyping and Business Model Development | Q4: Startup Ecosystem and Scale-up. Activities are also graded by intensity: Level 1 (awareness sessions) to Level 4 (extended hackathons exceeding 18 hours).

National Programmes That Flow Through IIC

The IIC network is not just about campus-level activities. It serves as the primary institutional pipeline for several major national programmes that carry real funding, mentorship, and career-building value.

Smart India Hackathon (SIH)

India's flagship open innovation model. First conducted in 2017, SIH has grown into the world's largest hackathon. SIH 2025 attracted 72,165 idea submissions from 68,766 teams across 2,587 institutes. Since inception, the programme has impacted over 13.9 lakh students and spawned over 100 startups. Problem statements come directly from central government ministries, state governments, and industry partners. IICs serve as the institutional coordination point for SIH participation - teams register and submit through the IIC mechanism.

> **IIT Bombay at SIH 2024**
> Three IIT Bombay teams won top prizes at the Smart India Hackathon 2024 Grand Finale. The institute explicitly credited its Institution's Innovation Council for facilitating student participation and mentorship throughout the competition cycle.

YUKTI Innovation Repository and Challenge

YUKTI (Young India's Ubiquitous Knowledge Through Innovation) is a centralised digital platform cataloguing innovations from across the country. Over 1,02,000 innovations from 1,600+ institutions have been registered - including 6,155+ startups, 38,000+ prototypes, and 56,000+ ideas. The YUKTI Innovation Challenge provides mentoring, multi-stage evaluation, and funding support for innovations at Technology Readiness Level (TRL) 4 and above. Over 130 innovations have received direct funding through this channel.

KAPILA - Kalam Program for IP Literacy and Awareness

Named after Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam, KAPILA reimburses government patent filing charges up to ₹5,600 per application and runs IP awareness clinics through IIC institutions. This is a tangible, direct financial benefit - any student or faculty member whose innovation merits a patent can get filing costs covered through this programme.

IDE Bootcamps

Five-day immersive Innovation, Design, and Entrepreneurship (IDE) bootcamps that train students in design thinking, rapid prototyping, and business model development. Approximately 10,000 participants were trained in the 2025 edition. These are intensive, hands-on programmes - a significant step up from typical campus workshops.

Innovation Ambassador Training

A large-scale faculty development programme that has trained over 25,000 faculty and school teachers as certified Innovation Ambassadors. These ambassadors serve as the knowledge backbone of the IIC network, conducting workshops, mentoring students, and bridging the gap between academic theory and entrepreneurial practice.

Mentor-Mentee Scheme

High-performing IICs (rated 3.5 stars or above) are paired with up to five lower-performing IICs for structured guidance. This creates a peer-learning network where experienced councils share best practices, activity templates, and operational know-how with newer or struggling ones.

Performance Evaluation: The Star Rating System

The IIC Star Rating System is a rigorous annual evaluation framework that makes innovation performance measurable and comparable across all participating institutions.

How Scoring Works

Ratings range from 0 to 5 stars, awarded in half-star increments. The scoring mechanism allocates a maximum of 100 points:

Component	Weightage	Details
Activity Score	80%	Covers all four activity pillars across four quarters. Each quarter carries a maximum of 25 marks (equivalent to 1 star). Minimum prescribed activities across all categories for all four quarters yields a maximum of 4 stars.
Reward Score	20%	Participation in broader MIC initiatives, exceptional achievements, and innovation outputs beyond the prescribed calendar.
Fifth Star	Discretionary	Reserved for MIC to award at its discretion to institutions demonstrating exceptional achievements - significantly exceeding minimums, active participation in national programmes, and outstanding innovation outcomes.

The Evaluation Process

1. After each activity, IICs upload detailed reports (photographs, attendance sheets, event details, YouTube video links) to the IIC portal
2. MIC reviewers evaluate each submission and approve, disapprove, or reopen it for revision
3. Disapproved activities reduce the total score - quality matters as much as quantity
4. Quarterly scores are calculated and released to each IIC
5. An annual performance report with final star ratings is announced publicly at a national event

Why Star Ratings Matter

Star ratings have real consequences. In IIC 4.0 (2021–22), only 59 institutions out of thousands earned the highest 4-star rating - the bar is genuinely high. Institutions rated 3.5 stars and above are designated as “best performing” and invited to serve as mentors. Most importantly, star ratings directly influence institutional standing in the NIRF Innovation ranking (formerly ARIIA), which was integrated into the National Institutional Ranking Framework. For any institution that cares about its national ranking, IIC performance is now a formal input.

How IIC Differs From Other Student Bodies

This is perhaps the most important distinction for the IIT Bombay community to understand. The campus already has a rich ecosystem of student-run organisations. Where does IIC fit?

The Fundamental Difference

Student bodies like E-Cell, technical councils, coding clubs, and cultural committees are typically student-initiated, student-run organisations that report to the Gymkhana or Dean of Students. They choose their own activities, set their own timelines, and operate with significant autonomy.

IIC operates in an entirely different orbit. It is not a replacement for any of these bodies. It is a structurally distinct, government-mandated layer that complements them.

Dimension	Student Bodies (E-Cell, Tech Clubs, etc.)	Institution's Innovation Council (IIC)
Origin	Student-initiated; organically evolved	Government-mandated by Ministry of Education via MIC
Leadership	Student-led; faculty advisor in supporting role	Faculty-led (President must be senior faculty); students are coordinators
Governance	Reports to Gymkhana / Dean of Students	Reports to MIC (national body) via the IIC portal
Activity Calendar	Self-determined; flexible	Mandatory national calendar with prescribed activities per quarter
Evaluation	Internal; no external rating	National star rating system (0–5 stars); quarterly review by MIC
External Members	Typically students only	Includes alumni entrepreneurs, industry experts, patent agents
National Linkage	Limited; operates within institute	Direct pipeline to SIH, YUKTI, KAPILA, IDE Bootcamps, and MIC programmes
Impact on Rankings	Indirect	Directly feeds into NIRF Innovation ranking
Scope	Often focused (entrepreneurship, or coding, or a specific domain)	Full spectrum: ideation → IPR → pre-incubation → startup support
Accountability	To student community and institute	To a national government body with formal reporting requirements

Think of it this way

If E-Cell is the entrepreneurship club that inspires and energises students, IIC is the government-backed institutional framework that ensures innovation support exists at every college in India - with accountability, measurement, funding pipelines, and national coordination. At IIT Bombay, they complement each other powerfully.

IIC at IIT Bombay

IIT Bombay registered its IIC during the programme's inaugural year in 2018, with **Registration ID: IC201810679**. The institution has trained Innovation Ambassadors and adopted the National Innovation and Startup Policy (NISP), as confirmed in its official ARIIA filing.

The Existing Innovation Ecosystem

IIT Bombay already possesses one of India's most mature innovation ecosystems, into which IIC integrates as a government compliance and coordination layer:

Entity	Established	Role
SINE (Society for Innovation & Entrepreneurship)	2004	Technology business incubator; has incubated 200+ startups
E-Cell (Entrepreneurship Cell)	1998	Student-run body; organises E-Summit (30,000+ footfall), Eureka!, and startup mentoring
DSSE (Desai Sethi School of Entrepreneurship)	2017	Academic unit; offers 20+ courses, minor degree, and pre-incubation programmes
IRCC (Industrial Research Consultancy Centre)	1974	Manages industry-sponsored research, IP, and technology transfer
BETIC (Biomedical Engineering & Technology Innovation Centre)	-	Healthcare innovation and medical device development
IIT Bombay Research Park	-	Industry co-location and collaborative research facility

IIC's Specific Role at IIT Bombay

Given IIT Bombay's already powerful ecosystem, IIC functions more as a government compliance and national coordination layer than as the primary innovation driver. Specifically, at IIT Bombay, IIC's role includes:

- Coordinating institutional participation in Smart India Hackathon - three IIT Bombay teams won top prizes at SIH 2024, with IIC facilitating participation and mentorship
- Connecting students to KAPILA for patent filing support and IP awareness
- Providing a formal channel to register innovations on the YUKTI platform
- Contributing to IIT Bombay's NIRF Innovation ranking through documented innovation activities

- Organising or co-organising events like Greenovate 2025 (sustainability innovation showcase, alongside Centre for Climate Studies and DSSE)
- Filing quarterly activity reports to MIC, ensuring the institution’s innovation efforts are nationally visible and counted

Scope of IIC: What It Can Do For Different Stakeholders

For students and faculty at IIT Bombay, understanding IIC's scope is essential to leveraging its full potential. IIC is not merely an administrative body - it is a gateway to a wide array of tangible resources, opportunities, and support systems.

For Students

- Access to the Smart India Hackathon: Solve real government and industry problems, win prizes, and potentially convert solutions into startups
- Patent filing support through KAPILA: Get your innovation's patent filing costs reimbursed (up to ₹5,600 per application)
- Register your innovation on YUKTI: Get national visibility, mentoring, and potential funding for prototypes at TRL 4+
- Attend IDE Bootcamps: Intensive five-day design thinking and prototyping programmes
- Connect with mentors: Through IIC's external members, Innovation Ambassadors, and mentor-mentee networks
- Build your innovation portfolio: Participation in IIC activities is documented nationally and can strengthen your CV/profile
- Startup support pathway: From ideation workshops through IPR guidance to pre-incubation referrals

For Faculty

- Become a certified Innovation Ambassador: Gain formal training and national recognition in innovation and entrepreneurship mentoring
- Access IPR support: KAPILA covers patent filing fees for faculty innovations as well
- Contribute to institutional rankings: Your innovation activities, when reported through IIC, directly feed into NIRF Innovation scores
- Industry connections: IIC's mandate to include external industry experts creates structured networking opportunities
- Professional development: MIC-organised programmes, leadership talks, and regional meets offer continuous learning
- Research commercialisation pathway: IIC connects to national frameworks for technology transfer and startup creation from research

For the Institution

- NIRF Innovation ranking: IIC activities directly influence IIT Bombay's standing in national rankings

- Government compliance: IIC membership is now mandatory for AICTE-approved institutions
- National visibility: Well-performing IICs gain recognition at regional and national levels through star ratings
- Policy access: IIC provides a formal channel for institutional feedback to the Ministry of Education on innovation policy
- Ecosystem benchmarking: Star ratings allow comparison with peer institutions nationwide

Why IIC Matters: The Bigger Picture

India's Innovation Ambition

India's Global Innovation Index ranking has improved dramatically - from 86th in 2015 to 38th by 2024 - with a stated national target of reaching the Top 20. IIC is positioned as a central instrument in this journey. The logic is clear: if you can create a functioning innovation ecosystem at 16,400+ institutions simultaneously, you multiply the country's innovation capacity by orders of magnitude compared to relying on a handful of premier institutions.

Democratising Innovation

Perhaps IIC's most profound contribution is democratisation. Before IIC, innovation support in Indian higher education was concentrated at the top - IITs, IIMs, NITs, and a few private universities. The vast majority of students at smaller colleges had no exposure to design thinking, no awareness of intellectual property, no access to hackathons or mentors. IIC changed this equation by mandating and structuring innovation activities at every institution, with central coordination and accountability. A student at a small engineering college in Jharkhand now has access to the same Smart India Hackathon, the same KAPILA patent support, and the same YUKTI platform as a student at IIT Bombay.

Building the Innovation Pipeline

IIC creates a complete pipeline from awareness to commercialisation:

- Awareness: Celebration Day activities and orientation sessions expose students to the concept of innovation
- Ideation: Design thinking workshops and idea competitions help students develop problem-solving skills
- Skill Building: IDE Bootcamps and Innovation Ambassador-led sessions build technical and entrepreneurial capabilities
- Prototyping: Hackathons (especially SIH) push students to build working solutions within tight deadlines
- IP Protection: KAPILA provides the knowledge and financial support to file patents
- Validation: YUKTI catalogues innovations and the YUKTI Innovation Challenge provides expert evaluation
- Incubation: Top innovations are connected to institutional incubators (like SINE at IIT Bombay) for further development
- Startup Creation: The full pipeline from ideation to market-ready product is supported through IIC's ecosystem

Future Outlook

The IIC programme's trajectory is ambitious, with several major initiatives signalling its future direction:

City Innovation Clusters

Piloted in Visakhapatnam in June 2025, this model aims to scale across 250 cities. Each cluster brings together institutions, industries, and investors around local strengths, with structured innovation centres for research, prototyping, and technology transfer on a three-year roadmap. This shifts IIC from a purely campus-level body to a city-level economic development mechanism.

Indovation Centres

12–13 regional hubs planned in cities including Kanpur, Bhopal, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Chennai, and Kolkata. Each centre will facilitate technology commercialisation, supporting over 1,000 projects annually, backed by a $10 million annual joint investment with the Wadhwani Foundation through the AICTE iCube Innovation Council (a Section 8 non-profit).

Academic Credits for Innovation

AICTE has introduced academic credits for students working on startup projects, even at the ideation stage. This is a paradigm shift - it formally recognises innovation work as equivalent to academic coursework, removing one of the biggest barriers for students who want to pursue entrepreneurship without sacrificing grades.

School Innovation Councils

The School Innovation Council programme has already reached 2,800+ schools, extending the innovation pipeline down to pre-university education. This creates a feeder system where students arrive at college with baseline innovation skills and mindsets - a structural change in India's education pipeline.

Expansion Beyond Technical Institutions

Prof. T.G. Sitharam, AICTE Chairman, announced at the IIC Regional Meet in November 2025 that the programme would expand beyond technical institutions to encompass all types of higher education institutions - arts, commerce, science, and professional colleges. This could potentially double or triple the network's reach.

Key Resources and Contact Points

Resource	URL / Contact	Purpose
IIC Official Portal	iic.mic.gov.in	Activity reporting, performance tracking, registration
MoE's Innovation Cell	mic.gov.in	National coordination, policy updates, programme announcements
Smart India Hackathon	sih.gov.in	Hackathon registration, problem statements, team submissions
YUKTI Portal	yukti.mic.gov.in	Innovation registration, challenge submissions, funding opportunities
KAPILA Portal	kapila.mic.gov.in	Patent filing support and IP literacy resources
IDE Bootcamp	bootcamp.mic.gov.in	Bootcamp registration and resources
SINE (IIT Bombay)	sineiitb.org	Incubation support for IIT Bombay innovators
E-Cell (IIT Bombay)	ecell.in	Student entrepreneurship activities and events
DSSE (IIT Bombay)	dsse.iitb.ac.in	Academic programmes in entrepreneurship and pre-incubation

Conclusion

The Institution's Innovation Council represents something genuinely new in Indian higher education: a nationally standardised, government-mandated, measurably accountable framework for building innovation culture across thousands of institutions simultaneously. It is not a student club, not a voluntary initiative, and not limited to premier institutions.

Its strength lies in three dimensions: scale (16,400+ councils reaching 50 lakh+ people), structure (prescribed calendars, star ratings, quarterly accountability), and connectivity (direct pipeline to national programmes worth real funding and mentorship).

For IIT Bombay's students and faculty, IIC matters as the formal bridge between campus innovation and national policy infrastructure - the channel through which SIH participation is coordinated, YUKTI innovations are catalogued, patent filing costs are reimbursed, and institutional innovation performance is measured against every other college in India.

Whether you are a student with a prototype looking for mentorship and funding, or a faculty member exploring technology transfer, the IIC network and its associated programmes represent a government-backed resource that complements IIT Bombay's already powerful innovation ecosystem. Understanding it, engaging with it, and leveraging it is not optional - it is increasingly essential.

Disclaimer

This report is prepared for informational purposes for the IIT Bombay community. Data cited is sourced from official MIC/AICTE publications, the IIC portal (iic.mic.gov.in), and publicly available institutional reports. Figures related to national programme outcomes (SIH participants, YUKTI registrations, etc.) reflect the latest available data as of March 2026 and may be subject to updates.